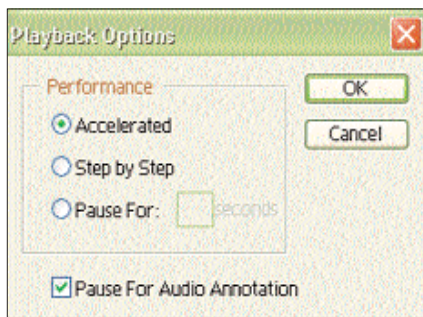


an action, open the actions palette and hold down [Ctrl] and double-click the command. You can also select a command in the actions palette and then press Play. This will execute the command you selected and all commands after that.

When you play any action, the individual commands are executed too fast to see their effect. If something goes wrong, you will not be able to trace the command that erred. Fortunately, you can control the action speed. In the actions palette, you will find Playback Options. This is where you can control the speed of the action. The default option here is Accelerated. If you choose 'Step by Step', after each command the image will be redrawn. You can also specify the amount of time to pause between each command.

Often you will need to edit or modify actions, especially if you have downloaded action scripts off the Internet. Repeating them step by step and changing a few commands can be painful. You may also want to rearrange commands, add a few commands, duplicate commands, or just delete a few commands. Most of this



Use Playback Options to select how fast actions should play

can be achieved by dragging and dropping with your mouse.

To rearrange commands within an action, go to the actions palette and just drag a command and drop it to the chosen place on the list. To add commands at the end of the list, just press record and perform the command. Alternatively, you can select a command, press record and execute the action you want to add—this will add the new command just after the selected command.

To rearrange actions, drag the action to its new location before or after another action. When the highlighted line appears in the desired position, release the mouse button. Use the same procedure to arrange commands within actions to change their order of execution. If you want to re-record any command, just double-click on it, enter new values and click OK. But if you want to record the whole action, click the name of the action and choose 'Record Again...' from the palette menu. To copy a command, simply hold the [Alt] key and drag it to a new location. For deleting sets, actions or commands, select them and click on the trash icon, or drag them to the trash icon. You can also choose 'Clear All Actions' from the Actions palette menu to delete all your actions.

Photoshop 7 automatically saves all actions in the actions palette on exit to the **Settings > Actions Palette** folder. However, if you want to choose a location, so that you can share them with your friends or even on the Internet, open the Actions palette, select a set and click on Save Actions. The actions will be saved as .atn files. If you hold [Ctrl] + [Alt] while clicking on Save Actions, all the commands in that action will be saved as a text file. However, this text file can only be used as reference or for printing, and cannot be loaded into Photoshop again.

Once you have saved your Actions as .atn files, you can play them on any

machine running Photoshop. The Action files, which are available on the Internet are also in this format. To use these Actions, first you will have to load them by choosing 'Load Actions' from the Actions palette menu, and then locating and selecting the action set file, and then clicking Load. Now you will see all the Actions contained in that .atn file in the Actions palette.

If you have a few images, you can open them individually and perform an action, but if you have too many, you will need to use the Batch command by going to **File > Automate > Batch**. This lets you play an action on a folder of files and subfolders. You can choose to leave all the files open, close and save over the originals, or save the modified versions of the files to a new location.

Choose the desired set and action that you want to play, and choose the source folder of the files. Select 'Override Action "Open" Commands' if you want 'Open commands' in the action to refer to the batched files, rather than the filenames specified in the action. Remember, if you select this option, the action must contain an Open command because the Batch command will not automatically open the source files. Now, Select 'Include All Subfolders' to process files in subfolders. Select 'Suppress Color Profile Warnings' to turn off all Color Policy messages. Choose a destination for the processed files from the Destination menu. Select 'Override Action "Save As" Commands' if you want all 'Save As' commands in the action to refer to the batched files. If you chose Folder as the destination, specify a file-naming convention and select file compatibility options for the processed files.

Saving files using the Batch command options always saves the files in the same format as the original files. To create a batch process that saves files in a new format, record the Save As command followed by the Close command as part of your original action. Then choose 'Override Action "Save In" Commands' for the Destination when setting up the batch process. Now, click OK to begin the batch execution of the files.

There are other Photoshop features that are based on actions, such as Droplets, Picture Package, Contact Sheet and Web Photo Gallery. Explore them, and you will surely be amazed by their power and ease. You can also download actions files from the Internet and try them out. Happy Actioning!

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